

ITEM WISE EDITORIAL ... 10th June, 2019



IMMEDIATE NEIGHBOURHOOD ... TRANSFORMATIONAL RELATIONS

GS - II

International Relations



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... DISCUSSION

10th JUNE, 2019

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Itinerary symbolism

The second Modi government sends a powerful 'neighbourhood first' message

In a reaffirmation of New Delhi's 'Neighbourhood First' policy, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's first visit abroad is to the Maldives and Sri Lanka, while S. Jaishankar wraps up his first visit abroad as Foreign Minister to Bhutan. Leaders of several neighbouring countries were invited to Mr. Modi's swearing-in ceremony. This is the first state visit by Mr. Modi to Male, which he had visited briefly for the swearing-in of President Ibrahim Mohamed Solih in November 2018. A series of agreements are expected during the visit, including the implementation of an \$800 million Line of Credit to the Maldives. The projects include a cricket stadium, water purification and sewerage systems, as well as a Coastal Surveillance Radar System and a Composite Training Centre for the Maldives National Defence Force. This follows the Indian practice of fulfilling the needs of neighbouring countries that they themselves identify, much as it has done in Afghanistan. The Prime Minister's visit to the Maldives aims to send a three-pronged message: to continue high-level contacts between close neighbours, assist as development partners, and strengthen people-to-people ties. For Sri Lanka, Mr. Modi's message is one of solidarity in the aftermath of the Easter Sunday terror attacks and the communal violence that followed, as well as a commitment to continue bilateral cooperation on joint development projects agreed to in 2007. He will be the first international leader to visit Colombo since the attacks, and his visit sends a powerful message as Sri Lanka tries to recover from the trauma.

The atmospherics today are in contrast to the comparatively trickier relationship with the previous governments in Male and Colombo during Mr. Modi's first tenure. In 2015, Mr. Modi had cancelled a visit to Male at the last minute following concerns over then President Abdulla Yameen's crackdown on Opposition parties. Similar misgivings had cropped up regarding former Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapaksa's regime. China's inroads into the region had formed a common thread straining ties with both countries. India protested when the Yameen government signed a five-trade agreement with Beijing, and granted China land for development. It made its displeasure clear over the many infrastructure projects Mr. Rajapaksa granted to Chinese companies under heavy Chinese loans. Deeper concerns arose from the Chinese naval presence in both Male and Colombo. Now, the situation has turned. Governments in both countries have changed. Besides a claims offensive, India has chosen to mute its opposition to their continued cooperation with China on the Belt and Road Initiative. It also comes from a realisation in Delhi that at a time when factors such as the U.S.-China trade tensions and tensions in West Asia pose uncertainties, strong neighbourhood ties can provide much comfort.

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

India and its neighbourhood- relations.

DRAFT QUESTION

“India’s transformational relationships in the immediate neighbourhood can have overwhelming effect than the transactional relations of China”.
Discuss.

1 Itinerary symbolism

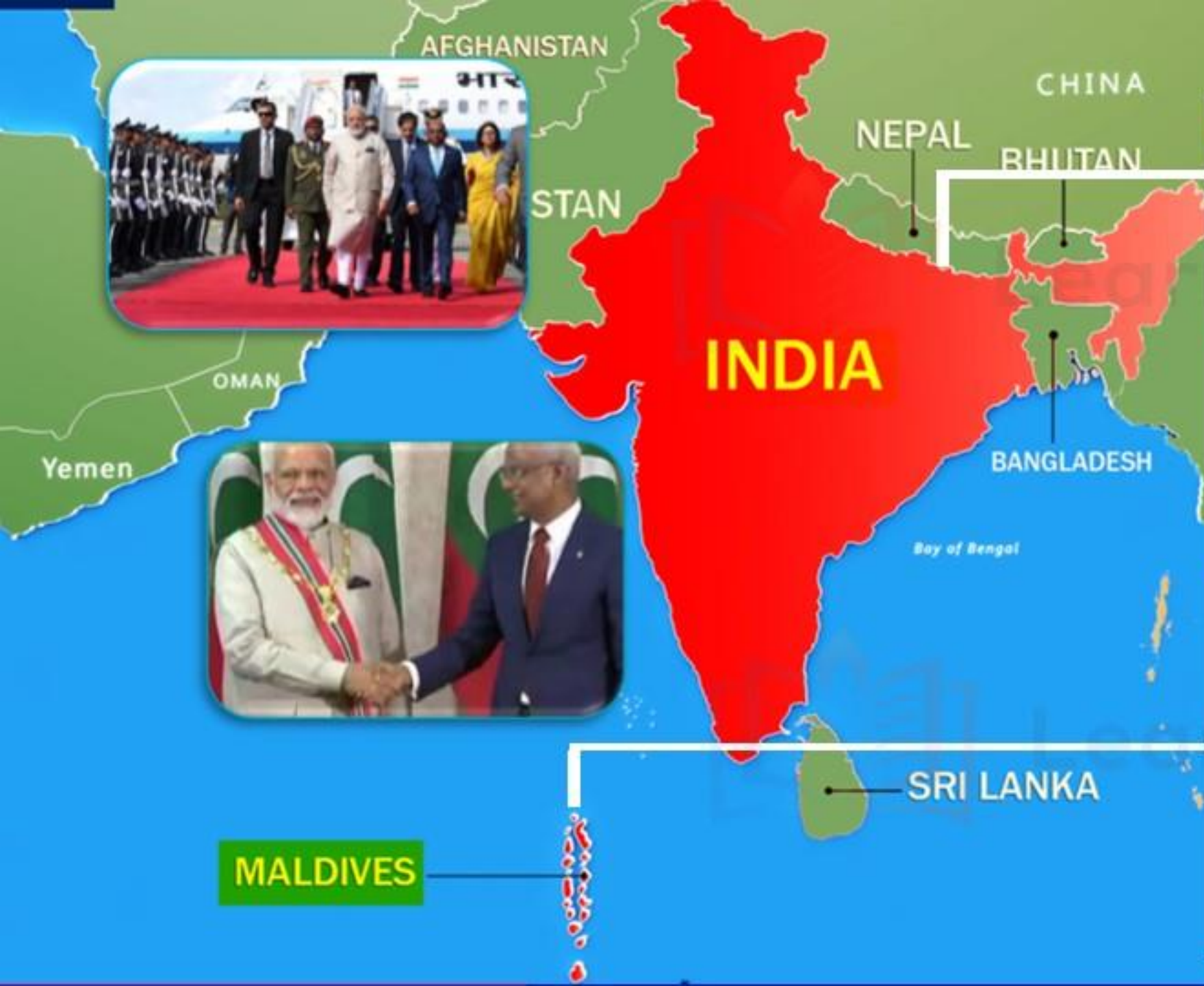
The second Modi government sends a powerful 'neighbourhood first' message

In a reaffirmation of New Delhi's 'Neighbourhood First' policy, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's first visit abroad is to the Maldives and Sri Lanka, while S. Jaishankar wraps up his first visit abroad as Foreign Minister to Bhutan. Leaders of several neighbouring countries were invited to Mr. Modi's swearing-in ceremony. This is the first state visit by Mr. Modi to Male, which he had visited briefly for the swearing-in of President Ibu Solih in November 2018. A series of agreements are expected during the visits, including the implementation of an \$800 million Line of Credit to the Maldives. The projects include a cricket stadium, water purification and sewerage systems, as well as a Coastal Surveillance Radar System and a Composite Training Centre for the Maldives National Defence Force. This follows the Indian practice of fulfilling the needs of neighbouring countries that they themselves identify, much as it has done in Afghanistan. The Prime Minister's visit to the Maldives aims to send a three-pronged message: to continue high-level contacts between close neighbours, assist as development partners, and strengthen people-to-people ties. For Sri Lanka, Mr. Modi's message is one of solidarity in the aftermath of the Easter Sunday terror attacks and the communal violence that followed, as well as a commitment to continue bilateral cooperation on joint development projects agreed to in 2017. He will be the first international leader to visit Colombo since the attacks, and his visit sends a powerful message as Sri Lanka tries to recover from the trauma.

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- Prime Minister visited Maldives, his first State visit abroad, since being re-elected to Office.
- Six agreements were signed, Maldives conferred upon Mr. Modi highest honor, the “Rule of Nishan Izzuddin”.
- The Prime Minister addressed the Maldivian Parliament, “The Majlis”.
- The Prime Minister said “Combating Terrorism and Radicalization” is the most accurate test of the leadership in the World.

OTHER ASPECTS OF PRIME MINISTER'S MALE VISIT



- 1 Both the leaders jointly inaugurated a “Coastal Surveillance Radar System” and the training facility of the Maldives National Defence Force by a remote link.
- 2 Both the leaders welcomed the signing of \$ 800 million Line of Credit agreement in March 2019.
- 3 Both the countries decided to start a ferry service between Kochi and Maldives.

PRIME MINISTER'S VISIT TO SRI LANKA

INDIA

- It is incidental to mention that more than 250 people died, including 11 Indians in the Easter Terror Attacks recently.
- Shri Narendra Modi is the first foreign Head of the State to visit the island after the carnage.
- The main focus of the interactions is cooperation in economic initiatives and countering terrorism.
- It is basically termed as "Solidarity Visit".



SRI LANKA

The President of Sri Lanka presented the Prime Minister with the replica of Samadhi Buddha statue, hand carved in white teak.



WHAT TO THEY SIGNIFY?

VISIT TO THE MALDIVES

- To continue high level contacts between close neighbors.
- To assist as development partner.
- To strengthen people to people ties.



VISIT TO THE SRI LANKA

- It is one of the solidarity after Easter Sunday Terror attacks and the communal violence that followed.
- Commitment to continue bilateral cooperation on joint development projects agreed to in 2017.
- As India's Prime Minister is the first International leader to visit Colombo since the attacks, it gives underlying message.



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